

THE WHITE HOUSE
Washington, D.C.

Reykjavik

October 10, 1986

Dear Mr. Chairman,

As I meet this week with General Secretary Gorbachev in Reykjavik, Iceland, I believe it is crucial that the Congress join with me in forging a strong bipartisan consensus on a nuclear testing policy that promotes our national security interests and advances long-standing U.S. arms control objectives.

As you are well aware, the Senate and House versions of the National Defense Authorization Act for Fiscal Year 1987 contain different amendments on the nuclear testing issue. The Senate bill includes non-binding language urging me, at the earliest possible date, to request advice and consent of the Senate (if necessary, with a reservation on the subject of verification) to the Threshold Test Ban and Peaceful Nuclear Explosions Treaties (TTBT/PNET) and to propose to the Soviet Union the immediate resumption of negotiations toward conclusion of a verifiable comprehensive test ban (CTB) treaty. The House bill would mandate a one-year moratorium on U.S. nuclear tests above one kiloton ... provided the Soviet Union demonstrates matching restraint and agrees to reciprocal in-country monitoring arrangements.

I fully recognize the difficult challenge you have faced in trying to reconcile these differing positions in the conference on this bill. However, I do not believe it is in the best interests of our Nation for this dispute to remain unresolved. I think it may be helpful if I were to identify some basic principles upon which I believe we all agree and to outline my plans for discussing this issue in Reykjavik.

First, let me emphasize that I am committed to the ultimate attainment of a total ban on nuclear testing, a goal that has been endorsed by every U.S. President since President Eisenhower. I am determined to take practical steps in the near future toward this goal.

Second, I am sure we are in full accord that any treaties with the Soviet Union in the arms control area -- whether they be treaties requiring reductions in deployed weapons or treaties

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limiting nuclear testing -- must be verifiable. In recent years, advances in technology have made possible methods of improved verification in the nuclear testing area that can and should be incorporated in both pending and any future nuclear testing agreements with the Soviet Union.

Third, I believe that we fully recognize that for over four decades we have relied upon nuclear weapons for the deterrence of war and that nuclear testing has been instrumental in ensuring the safety and reliability of these weapons. A CTB would necessarily require a completely different approach to meeting our crucial interests in the areas of nuclear weapons safety and reliability -- interests that will remain vital as long as the United States continues to depend on the threat of nuclear retaliation to deter aggression. Thus how one transitions to a total test ban regime is no less critical a concern than verification or any other national security issue related to an eventual implementation of a CTB.

With these principles in mind, I am prepared to take two important steps toward limiting nuclear testing. First, I intend -- inform General Secretary Gorbachev in Reykjavik that as a first order of business for the 100th Congress, if the Soviet Union will, prior to the initiation of ratification proceedings in the Senate next year, agree to essential TBT/PWT verification procedures which could be submitted to the Senate for its consideration in the form of a protocol or other appropriate codicil, I will request the advice and consent of the Senate to ratification of the TTB and PWT treaties. However, if the Soviet Union fails to agree to the required package of essential procedures prior to the convening of the 100th Congress, I will still make ratification of these treaties a first order of business for the Congress, with an appropriate reservation to the treaties that would ensure they would not take effect until they are effectively verifiable. I will work with the Senate in drafting this reservation.

Second, I intend to inform the General Secretary in Reykjavik that, once our verification concerns have been satisfied and the treaties have been ratified, I will propose that the United States and the Soviet Union immediately engage in negotiations on ways to implement a step-by-step parallel program -- in association with a program to reduce and ultimately eliminate all nuclear weapons -- of limiting and ultimately ending nuclear testing. These steps we can take in the near future -- steps which will show the world that the United States is moving forward.

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I believe that the approach outlined in this letter is consistent with the broad purposes and objectives of the Congress with respect to limiting nuclear testing. I hope that this communication will prove constructive in assisting you to reach final agreement on a Fiscal Year 1967 defense authorization bill and will provide a foundation for a bipartisan consensus on this important policy issue.

Ronald Reagan

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